

E-BOOK · SECOND EDITION · 2026

Claude, Practically at your pace

A field guide to working with AI — written for people who are building the next chapter of their working life, at whatever age that chapter arrives.

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About this edition

This is the second edition of a guide that began life in Polish. It has been rebuilt rather than translated: new case studies, a chapter on your data, corrected product facts, an honest time budget, and a closing invitation that has nothing to do with software.

Written by

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INDEPENDENT PUBLICATION

This guide is written by an independent practitioner. It is not affiliated with, endorsed by, or sponsored by Anthropic PBC. "Claude" is a trademark of Anthropic PBC, used here descriptively to name the product this guide teaches. All opinions, methods and errors are the author's own.

ACCURACY AND SHELF LIFE

Every product claim here was checked in July 2026. AI tools change monthly — features move between plans, names change, limits shift. Treat every plan name, price and feature note as illustrative and verify the current state at claude.com/pricing and support.claude.com.

The durable part of this book is the method: context, iteration, projects, deliberate memory, delegation, and verification. That will still be true when the version numbers have all moved on.

Second edition, 2026. Written in Poland and Norway.

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Who this book is for

Short answer: anyone who works with their head and is running out of hours. Longer answer: I wrote it with three groups sitting in front of me.

Women stepping into the next chapter — often at forty-plus

I am an ambassador for women in business, and this is the group I meet most often. Women returning after a break. Women who have carried a department for fifteen years and are now building something of their own. Women with more competence than time, who have been told — usually by implication rather than out loud — that new technology belongs to someone younger.

It does not. The single biggest advantage in working with AI is knowing what a good result looks like, and that advantage compounds with experience. You already have it. What you are missing is a map, and this book is the map.

Generation Z — early in the career, high on the learning curve

If you are twenty-three and drafting your first client proposal, your problem is the opposite one: fluency with tools, thinner ground truth. AI will happily hand you a confident, professional-looking answer that is wrong, and early in a career you have fewer instincts for catching it. So the chapters on verification and on critique matter more to you than the chapters on speed. Use this book to build judgement, not just output.

The parents of Generation Alpha

My daughter's generation will never remember a working world without this. What they learn from watching us is whether AI is a machine for avoiding thought or a partner for extending it. That is decided at kitchen tables, not in schools. There is a short chapter for you in Part IV.

You do not need to become a different person to use this well. You need a map, one honest hour, and permission to reclaim a few of your own weeks.

How to use this book — an honest time budget

The first edition promised "sixty minutes." That was true of the reading and false of everything else. Here is the real shape of it.

STAGE	REAL TIME	WHAT YOU GET
Reading, start to finish	~60 minutes	The map. What is possible, and what most people never discover.
Setup and first exercises	~90 minutes	Installed, configured, first project built, first real result in hand.
The 30-day plan	~20 min/day	The habit. This is the part that actually changes your week.

So: one hour to read, one evening to set up, one month to make it yours. Anyone promising less is selling something.

Read it with the app open

Please do not read this like a book. Read it with Claude open beside you. Every chapter ends with a box marked **DO THIS NOW**. Those boxes are the book. The prose between them is just enough context to make each box make sense.

Three ways to read it

IF YOU HAVE	DO THIS
One hour	Read Parts I and II. Do the four boxes. You will already be ahead of most people using this tool.
One evening	Read the whole book, do every box, then start Week 1 of the plan tomorrow morning.
Ten minutes	Go straight to the Prompt Library at the back. Steal three prompts. Come back later.

DO THIS NOW

Decide which of the three rows above is you, and write the date you will start the 30-day plan somewhere you will see it. A plan without a date is a wish.

NAVIGATION

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PART I

Start

What this thing actually is, which door to walk through, and the five minutes of setup that decide how good the next thirty days will be.

What Claude actually is

Claude is an AI assistant built by Anthropic. If you hear "AI assistant" and picture a chatbot you ask questions, you are right — and you are describing roughly a tenth of it.

A more useful picture: a capable colleague who happens to have no ego, no calendar and no memory of yesterday unless you give it one. That colleague can think with you, read your documents and spreadsheets and photographs, produce finished files you can send to a client, reach into your email and calendar when you allow it, work for an hour on something while you do something else, build small working tools without you writing code, and design what those tools look like.

The gap between someone getting ten per cent of that and someone getting eighty per cent is almost never intelligence, and almost never technical skill. It is knowing what exists. That is the entire content of the next hour.

The 80% map

In my own workshops the distribution looks roughly like this. It is an estimate from practice, not a survey — but the shape is consistent everywhere I have taught.

LEVEL	WHAT THEY ACTUALLY USE	ROUGHLY
Chat only	Questions in, short answers out. Copy-paste in both directions.	~80%
Files + projects	Documents in and out, organised workspaces, standing context.	~15%
Delegation + building	Long multi-step tasks, connected tools, small things built from scratch.	~5%

Most people stay in the first row forever, not because the second and third are hard, but because nobody told them the rows existed. The middle row is where the hours come back. The bottom row is where the interesting work is.

Row one saves you minutes. Row two saves you afternoons. Row three changes what you are able to offer.

Be honest about which row you are in today, and write it down. In thirty days you will read this page again, and the comparison is the point.

The 2026 map: one product, five doors

A lot of confusion comes from tutorials describing a version of this product that no longer exists. Here is the honest layout as of July 2026 — and a warning that it will move again.

DOOR	WHAT IT IS FOR	WHERE
Chat	Thinking, writing, analysis, files in and out. Where you live.	Web, desktop, mobile
Projects	Persistent workspaces with standing instructions and knowledge files.	Inside chat
Connectors	Letting Claude reach your mail, calendar, drive and other tools.	Settings
Cowork	Agentic sessions: long multi-step work on real files, with your approval at each decision point.	Its own tab
Code / Design	Building working software and visual material without writing either.	Own surfaces

CORRECTION TO THE FIRST EDITION

The first edition of this guide stated that Cowork had been folded into the main chat. That was wrong, and I would rather correct it loudly than quietly. As of July 2026 Cowork is still its own surface with its own tab — it began as a desktop app in January 2026 and has since expanded to web and mobile. Anthropic has publicly said it intends to unify Cowork with chat, but that is an announced direction, not a shipped state.

The lesson is bigger than the fact: **in this field, anything you read that is six months old is a hypothesis.** Including this page. Check it.

What you get without paying

The free plan is not a demo. During 2026 it has carried real work, including projects, artifacts and basic connectors. What you buy with a paid plan is mostly volume — more messages before you hit a wall — plus the heavier agentic surfaces and the strongest models. Current published pricing sits around \$20/month for Pro and \$100–\$200/month for the two Max tiers, but prices and tier contents both move, and they vary by region.

My advice has been the same for two years: **start free.** Upgrade the week you first feel a limit interrupt real work — that feeling is reliable data, and impatience is not.

DO THIS NOW

Open claude.com/pricing in a second tab and compare it to the table above. Whatever has changed since July 2026, you now know how to keep this book current.

Setup and the first five minutes

Four minutes of configuration decide how much of this book will work for you. Please do not skip them.

1 · Install the desktop app

Go to claude.ai, create an account, and install the desktop application for Windows or Mac. The desktop version can see files on your machine and supports things the browser cannot. Install the mobile app too — dictation and photographing documents are two of the highest-value habits in this book, and both live on the phone.

2 · Turn these on before your first message

- **Memory** — so Claude accumulates context about you across conversations.
- **Web search** — so it can check current facts rather than reconstructing them.
- **Artifacts** — the side panel where documents, tables and small tools appear and can be refined live.
- **File creation** — so you get real Word, Excel, PowerPoint and PDF files you can send onward.
- **Search past conversations** — so "find what we worked out last month" becomes a sentence instead of an archaeology project.

Settings menus get reorganised regularly; if a name has changed, look for the nearest equivalent rather than assuming the feature is gone.

3 · Language

Keep the interface in whatever language you like. Write to Claude in yours — Polish, Norwegian, English, all fine, including switching mid-sentence. It answers in the language you write in unless you ask otherwise. If you want output in a different language than your prompt, say so explicitly: *"Answer in English, I am writing in Polish."*

4 · Tell it who you are, once

Before anything else, spend three minutes writing a short profile of yourself into memory or your settings: what you do, who your clients or colleagues are, how you like output formatted, what you are working towards this year. Every future conversation starts warmer because of it.

DO THIS NOW

Install, sign in, enable the five settings, and write your three-minute profile. Then ask: *"Based on what you now know about me, what are three things you could take off my plate this week?"* That is your first real answer, and it is usually a good one.

PART II

Foundation

The difference between a mediocre answer and an excellent one is almost never the model. It is what you wrote. This part is about what you write.

How to talk so you get excellent results

Five rules. If you only ever learn the first and the third, you will already be in the top fifth of users.

Rule 1 · Context is eighty per cent of the result

Weak: *"Write a LinkedIn post about AI."*

Strong: *"I run a four-person accounting practice. My clients are local trades and small retailers who are nervous about technology. Write a LinkedIn post about what AI actually changes in bookkeeping — expert but plain, no jargon, maximum 150 words, ending with a question that invites replies."*

Claude reads everything you write with enormous care and nothing that you do not. The blank in the answer is almost always a blank in the question.

Rule 2 · A good request answers four questions

1. Who are you, and what is the situation?
2. What exactly do you want to receive?
3. What must be avoided or protected?
4. What should the output look like — format, length, tone?

When a result disappoints you, come back to this list before you complain. Nine times in ten, one of the four is missing.

Rule 3 · Conversation, not a vending machine

Iterate out loud. *"Good. Now cut it in half."* *"More direct, less warm."* *"Keep paragraph two, rewrite the rest."*

And the single highest-return sentence in this entire book, to be appended to any substantial request:

ADD THIS TO EVERY SERIOUS TASK

Before you write anything — ask me any questions you need in order to do this well.

Two clarifying questions at the start routinely save three rounds of revision at the end.

Rule 4 · Show, do not describe

If you have a piece of writing whose voice you want, paste it. *"Write in this style: [example]"* beats three paragraphs describing the style, every time. Same for a table you liked, a report format, a proposal structure.

Rule 5 · Make it think before it answers

For anything genuinely hard, add: *"Before you answer, lay out your reasoning step by step."* Visible reasoning materially raises quality on complex problems, and it lets you see where you disagree.

Four anti-patterns

- Cramming six unrelated tasks into one message. One task, one message.
- Keeping one conversation running for weeks. New topic, new chat.
- Accepting the first version of anything important.
- Arguing with a bad answer instead of rewriting the question.

DO THIS NOW

Take one real task from today. Write it using the four questions, and add the sentence from Rule 3. Then write the one-line version you would have sent before reading this. Compare the two results side by side.

Ten things no free tutorial will tell you

1 • Let Claude write the prompt

"I want to achieve [rough goal]. Before you do anything — write the ideal prompt I should be giving you, and show it to me for approval." It knows its own failure modes better than you do. This one habit replaces half of every prompt course being sold.

2 • Ask it to attack its own answer

"What is weakest in what you just wrote? Name three flaws and fix them." The default output is calibrated to "good enough." This is how you get the better version that was always available.

3 • Devil's advocate before every decision

"Argue against this. Give me the strongest case for not doing it, and tell me what I am not seeing." The cheapest strategic advisor you will ever retain, and the only one with no stake in your approval.

4 • Dictate instead of typing

Talk for two minutes as if explaining to a colleague in the corridor. A messy spoken monologue carries far more context than a tidy written sentence, and context is rule one.

5 • A screenshot is a universal language

Anything on your screen you cannot describe — an error, a chart, a badly designed form, a handwritten whiteboard — photograph it and ask. Claude reads images as fluently as text.

6 • It can search your own history

"Find our conversation about the Hansen proposal from three weeks ago and pick it up from there." No more scrolling.

7 • You control memory by hand

"What do you remember about me?" · "Remember that I always want reports as tables." · "Forget everything about the Kowalski project." Do the first one once a month. You will be surprised by both what it kept and what it did not.

8 • Incognito mode exists

For anything that should leave no trace in memory. Look for the incognito or private-chat option before you paste something sensitive, not after.

9 • Match the model to the task

Light edits, summaries and formatting do not need your most powerful model — and on a limited plan, spending your best model on tidying paragraphs means it is unavailable when you need real thinking.

Save the heavy model for judgement, structure and analysis.

10 · Three versions plus a decision table

"Give me three versions taking genuinely different approaches, then a table below: version / who it lands with best / main risk. Do not pick a winner." You get analysis instead of text, and you stay the one deciding.

DO THIS NOW

Pick one — ideally 1 or 3 — and use it in the next ten minutes on something real. These become part of you only after the first genuine use.

PART III

Your base

How to stop re-explaining yourself every morning — and how to decide, deliberately, what this tool is allowed to know about you and about the people who trust you.

Files, projects and memory

This chapter is the jump from row one to row two of the 80% map. It takes about fifteen minutes and it is the highest-return quarter-hour in the book.

Files, both directions

Drag in PDFs, Word documents, spreadsheets, CSVs, photographs, screenshots, presentations. Ask for finished files back: *"Give me this as a Word document"* or *"Build this as an Excel file with two sheets."* Artifacts open a side panel where the work appears and can be refined in place rather than regenerated from scratch each time.

Projects solve the amnesia problem

A project is a workspace with three things: standing instructions (who you are, what you expect, how you want output), knowledge files that stay loaded, and all the conversations on that theme. One project equals one role or one area — not one task.

GOOD PROJECT BOUNDARIES	WHY
"LinkedIn and thought leadership"	One voice, one audience, one set of examples.
"Client: Nordvik AS"	Contracts, history and constraints all in one place.
"Doctoral research"	Sources and terminology that must stay consistent.
"Household and finances"	Kept deliberately separate from everything professional.

Each project keeps its own context. They do not bleed into one another, which is exactly why you want more than one.

Memory, used deliberately

With memory on, Claude gradually accumulates what you do and prefer. Treat it as something you curate rather than something that happens to you: audit it monthly with *"What do you remember about me?"*, add what is missing, and delete what is stale. A memory full of last year's priorities quietly degrades every answer you get.

Projects plus curated memory are the moment it stops feeling like operating a tool and starts feeling like briefing a colleague who already knows the file.

DO THIS NOW

Create one project. Write four to six sentences of standing instructions and upload one or two context files. From today, every conversation on that subject happens inside it.

Your data, your rules

This chapter did not exist in the first edition, and leaving it out was the worst decision in that book. If you are in Europe, if you handle client material, or if you are about to connect your inbox — read this before Part IV.

I spend my professional life on ESG and governance, so I will be blunt: a guide that teaches you to upload thirty client invoices without a word about what that means is an incomplete guide.

Four questions to settle before you connect anything

1. **Whose data is it?** Your own notes are yours to do as you like with. Client contracts, patient details, employee records and supplier pricing belong to someone who has not been asked.
2. **What does your contract say?** Many professional and B2B agreements contain confidentiality clauses that cover processing by third-party services. Read yours before, not after.
3. **Do you need a data processing agreement?** Under GDPR, if you are a controller putting personal data through a service, this is a real question with a real answer. Business plans typically offer the necessary terms; consumer plans typically do not. Check current terms rather than assuming.
4. **Where does it run?** Consumer AI plans generally process data on the provider's infrastructure, which may sit outside the EEA. If data residency matters in your sector, that is a business-plan or enterprise conversation.

Five habits that cost you nothing

- **Redact before you upload.** Names, national ID numbers, account numbers and addresses can nearly always be replaced with "Client A" without weakening the analysis at all.
- **Use incognito for anything genuinely sensitive** — legal exposure, health, personnel matters, an offer you have not made yet.
- **Connect one tool at a time**, and only the ones you actually use. Broad access granted casually is the thing you will regret.
- **Check your own settings** for how your conversations may be used, and set them the way you want them. Do this consciously once rather than never.
- **Write it down.** One page: what you use AI for, what never goes in, who approved it. If a client ever asks, you will be glad it exists — and increasingly, clients ask.

THIS IS NOT LEGAL ADVICE

I am a strategist and a researcher, not your lawyer. This chapter tells you which questions to ask. For a binding answer about your obligations, ask someone qualified in your jurisdiction — and note that

regulation in this area is still moving.

DO THIS NOW

Write your one-page policy. Three headings: *what I use it for*, *what never goes in*, *what I redact first*. Ten minutes. Then put it in your project instructions so it applies automatically.

PART IV

Claude with hands

Everything so far has been conversation. This is where it starts finishing work — with your tools, on your files, while you are somewhere else entirely.

Connectors and delegation

Connectors: giving it reach

Connectors let Claude read your mail, calendar, drive and a growing list of other tools directly. Instead of copying and pasting, you ask: *"Has Nordvik replied about the June invoice, and where do we stand?"* or *"What does tomorrow look like — and find me a clear hour for a walk."*

Connect only what you use. Anything that changes or sends something should ask your permission first — and if it does not, that is a setting to go and find.

Delegation: the real shift

Here is the test. **If a task has more than three steps and a clearly describable end result, delegate it.** Claude plans, works in stages, uses the tools you have connected, reports as it goes, and comes back with something finished rather than something suggested.

TASK	BY HAND	YOUR INVOLVEMENT
28 invoices → categorised summary sheet	~45 min	~5 min
Five competitors → research deck	~3 hrs	~15 min
Weekly report from mail + calendar	~40 min	~5 min

These are my own measured figures from repeated runs, not marketing numbers. The elapsed time is longer than your involvement — Claude is working while you are not.

How to brief well — four rules

- 1. Describe the destination, not the route.** You want a summary sheet an accountant can use, not eleven steps of your own invention.
- 2. Hand over the materials and the access.** Files, folder, the relevant connector.
- 3. Set the boundaries explicitly.** *"Send nothing without my approval." "Where you cannot read something, flag it rather than guessing."*
- 4. Invite questions first.** *"Before you start, ask me anything unclear."*

DO THIS NOW

Connect one thing — calendar or mail. Ask something that requires looking inside it. Then delegate one real task of thirty minutes or more using the four rules above, and go and make tea. The tea is part of the exercise: you are practising not watching.

Case study: a folder of invoices

End of month. Twenty-eight cost invoices as PDFs. Your accountant needs a summary. By hand this is forty to fifty minutes of clicking and squinting.

Minutes 0–2 · The brief

COPY THIS

Here are 28 cost invoices for June. Build an Excel file. Sheet one: issue date, vendor, invoice number, net amount, VAT, gross amount, cost category — propose sensible categories yourself. Sheet two: totals by category plus a grand total.

Use only what is actually in the invoices. Where you cannot read something, put it in a "to check" column rather than guessing. Before you start, ask me anything unclear.

Minute 2 · Two questions

It asks about currency conversion and how to treat credit notes. You answer in one sentence each. This is the step people skip, and it is the step that makes the rest work.

Minutes 2–9 · It works, you do not

Roughly seven minutes of processing. You answer email. This is the part that feels strange the first time and normal by the third.

Minutes 9–11 · You verify

The file arrives with a summary. You spot-check three invoices at random against the sheet. They match. Then one more prompt:

THE AUDIT PASS — NEVER SKIP THIS

Now audit this sheet as an auditor being paid to find errors. Do the sums reconcile? Is any invoice duplicated or missing? Are the categories applied consistently? List everything you find, then fix it.

It finds one categorisation inconsistency and corrects it. The file goes to the accountant.

The arithmetic

	BY HAND	THIS WAY
Elapsed time	~45 min	~12 min

Your actual involvement

~45 min

~5 min

Both numbers matter and they are different numbers. Twelve minutes is how long the month-end task takes. Five minutes is how much of your attention it costs — and attention, not clock time, is the thing you are short of.

Next month: *"Do July exactly as we did June."* Inside a project, the format is already known. Eventually it becomes a scheduled task you simply receive.

DO THIS NOW

Reproduce this on your own files. No invoices? Use receipts, a messy contact list, a folder of meeting notes, or a year of bank statements. Copy the prompt and swap the nouns.

Four lives, four workflows

Invoices are universal, which is why they are the standard example — and also why they persuade nobody. These four are closer to the reasons people actually pick up this book. They are composites, drawn from women I have worked with.

Anna, 47 · Returning after seven years

Her problem is not competence. It is that seven years of running a household, a school board and a family business look like a gap on paper, and she has lost the vocabulary of her sector.

What worked: a project called "Return 2026" holding her old CV, three job adverts she wants, and a description of what she actually did in those seven years. Then, over a fortnight — a translation of unpaid work into professional language; a two-week reading list to rebuild sector vocabulary; her CV rewritten three ways for three different roles; and interview rehearsal, out loud, including the question she dreaded.

ANNA'S PROMPT

I am returning to work after seven years out. In that time I ran a household budget, chaired a school board and managed my husband's small business books. Interview me for twenty minutes about what I actually did, then translate it into the professional language of [sector] — as evidence, not as excuse. Ask questions one at a time.

"Ask questions one at a time" is the load-bearing phrase. A list of twenty questions is a form. One at a time is a conversation, and conversations produce better material.

Karolina, 52 · Building a consulting practice

Twenty years of corporate expertise, three clients, and no idea what to charge. Her real bottleneck was the unpaid work around the paid work: proposals, follow-ups, invoices, the website she kept not writing.

What worked: a proposal template built once and reused; pricing tested by having Claude argue against her rate as a sceptical buyer; a single client conversation turned into a month of LinkedIn posts; and a standing Monday briefing pulling together the week's commitments.

KAROLINA'S PROMPT

You are a sceptical procurement director at a mid-size manufacturer. I am proposing [service] at [rate]. Push back hard on the price, the scope and my credibility. Then step out of the role and tell me which of your own objections were fair and how I should have answered them.

Marta, 41 · Leading a team of twelve

Her calendar is the problem. Not thinking time — reaction time.

What worked: a daily briefing from calendar and inbox, ranked by consequence; meeting notes converted into decisions and owners the same hour; difficult messages drafted in two versions, firm and soft, so she chooses a strategy rather than agonising over wording; and a quarterly review where she pastes in her own calendar and asks what a competent outsider would say she is actually optimising for.

That last one is the uncomfortable exercise, and the valuable one.

Zofia, 23 · Two years into her first job

Fluent with the tool, thin on ground truth. She can generate a professional-looking document in four minutes and cannot always tell whether it is right.

Her practice is deliberately inverted: she writes first, then asks for critique. She asks for sources on every factual claim and opens them. And once a week she asks Claude to explain something in her field properly, then explains it back and asks what she got wrong.

ZOFIA'S PROMPT

Here is my draft. Do not rewrite it and do not praise it. Tell me: where a reader stops believing me, which sentences are padding, and what a senior person in this field would notice that I have missed. Then I will rewrite it myself.

Speed is the obvious gift for her generation. Judgement is the scarce one, and it is built by writing first and being corrected second.

For the parents of Generation Alpha

A short chapter, because it is a short point, and because it is the one I most want to be read.

My daughter's generation will never know a working world without this. They will not need to be taught how to use it — they will absorb the interface the way we absorbed the telephone. What they will need to be taught is something harder, and it is not on any school curriculum yet.

The only two questions that matter

"How do you know that is true?" and "What did you think before you asked?"

A child who habitually asks the first will grow up resistant to a category of manipulation their parents were not designed for. A child who habitually asks the second will keep the ability to have their own thoughts, which is quietly the thing at stake.

Three habits worth building at the kitchen table

- **Guess before you ask.** Written down, out loud, whatever — but a guess first, always. Then compare. This one habit is the difference between a tool that extends thinking and one that replaces it.
- **Check one thing.** Every time an answer will be used for something real, one claim gets verified against a source. Not all of them. One. Make it a ritual rather than a chore.
- **Let them see you disagree with it.** Say it out loud: *"That is wrong, and here is how I know."* A child who has never seen an adult correct an AI will assume that adults cannot.

What our children learn from watching us is not how to operate this. It is whether it is a machine for avoiding thought, or a partner for extending it. They are watching now.

ONE PRACTICAL NOTE

Most of these services have minimum ages and separate rules for younger users. Check them, and if a child in your house is using AI, use it beside them for the first few months rather than handing it over. The supervision is the curriculum.

DO THIS NOW

If there is a young person in your life, do one task together this week — homework, a trip plan, anything. Make them guess first. Then make them find one thing the answer got wrong. There is always one.

PART V

Level up

Building things you could not build before — and knowing exactly how and when this goes wrong, which is the more valuable half of the chapter.

Building things, and when Claude fails

Code, without coding

You describe what should exist in plain language; Claude writes, tests and improves the software. People with no technical background routinely build quote calculators, booking forms, small websites, file processors and internal dashboards. The workflow that works: ask for a plan, read the plan, approve or correct it, then build. At the end, ask Claude to write a context file describing what was built and why, so the next session starts informed instead of guessing.

Design, without a designer

Presentations, graphics, landing pages, prototypes — working from your own brand materials if you upload them first, which you should. The strongest sequence for anyone producing their own material is: **chat for the concept, design for the look, code to make it real.**

Mobile is not the lesser version

Dictation on a walk. Photographing a document, a whiteboard, a handwritten note. Checking on a long task from a train. For most of the people I teach, the phone is where the habit actually forms.

How this goes wrong

It will state untrue things with complete confidence. This is not a bug that is about to be fixed; it is a property of the technology, and your defence is procedural, not technical.

- **Always ask for sources and web verification** on anything concrete: figures, law, tax, quotations, dates, anything current, anything about a named person.
- **Spot-check data work.** Three random rows against the original, every time. It takes ninety seconds and it is the whole of your quality control.
- **Be most suspicious when the answer is exactly what you wanted.** That is the moment your own scepticism switches off.

Repair procedure, in order

1. Add the missing context — usually the real problem.
2. Show an example of what good looks like.
3. Break one large task into three smaller ones.
4. Start a fresh conversation. A chat that has gone wrong tends to stay wrong.

Agentic and computer-controlling features

The more agency you grant, the more your judgement is the safety mechanism. Prefer specific connectors over broad machine access. Close sensitive windows before you start a session. Keep permissions narrow and grant them deliberately. Watch the first few sessions closely rather than trusting immediately — and keep the rule that nothing gets sent, posted or paid without your explicit approval.

DO THIS NOW

Ask Claude something you already know the answer to well, in your own field of expertise. Notice how the answer feels. That calibration — knowing what a confidently wrong answer looks like from the inside — is worth more than any feature in this book.

PART VI

The plan

Knowledge is worthless if in a week you are back to old habits.
Thirty days, twenty minutes a day, and this becomes how you work
rather than something you once read about.

Your 30 days

Week 1 · Habit — it becomes the first reflex

- Move three recurring daily tasks into Claude. The same three, every day.
- Use the four-question structure every single time, even when it feels excessive.
- Test tip 1 — let it write the prompt — at least twice.
- Ask "What do you remember about me?" and correct it.

Week 2 · Base — it learns your world

- Build two or three projects with real instructions and real files.
- Write your one-page data policy from Chapter 7 into those instructions.
- Connect one or two connectors and run genuine work through them.

Week 3 · Delegation — it works while you are elsewhere

- Delegate three substantial tasks, thirty minutes or more each.
- Set one recurring or scheduled task.
- **Write down the hours you got back.** Actual numbers. This is the week people quietly stop, and the record is what stops them stopping.

Week 4 · Building — the first thing made from nothing

- Build one small tool, page or calculator.
- Produce one genuinely useful visual asset.
- Make next month's automation list, with Claude, using prompt 17.

The question to ask monthly, forever

THE RECURRING QUESTION

Here is what a typical working week looks like for me: [honest description, including the parts you are embarrassed by]. Which of these could you take over or substantially speed up — and where should I start, given that I will only sustain one change at a time?

And the meta-exercise, on day 30

CLOSING THE LOOP

Read back through our conversations from the last month and tell me how I have changed as a user — what I got better at, what I still avoid, and what I should learn next. One page. Be specific and do not flatter me.

That closes the loop. Then you start again, one row further down the 80% map.

The checklist

Print this page. Tick things off by hand — the physical act does something a digital list does not.

Week 1 · Habit

- ☐ Three daily tasks moved into Claude
- ☐ Every request uses the four-question structure
- ☐ Tested "let Claude write the prompt" twice
- ☐ Memory audited and corrected

Week 2 · Base

- ☐ Two or three projects created, with instructions and files
- ☐ One-page data policy written and installed
- ☐ One or two connectors connected
- ☐ Real work run through a connector

Week 3 · Delegation

- ☐ Three substantial tasks delegated
- ☐ One scheduled or recurring task set
- ☐ Reclaimed hours written down — actual number: _____
- ☐ One delegated result audited with the auditor prompt

Week 4 · Building

- ☐ One small tool or page built
- ☐ One useful visual created
- ☐ Next month's automation list made
- ☐ Day-30 meta-exercise completed

ONE HONEST NOTE

Most people stall in Week 3. Delegation requires trusting something with a piece of work before you have evidence it deserves the trust, and that is a genuinely uncomfortable step rather than a technical one. If you stall there, shrink the task until it is small enough to risk — and then do it anyway.

APPENDIX

The prompt library

Twenty-four prompts to copy, adapt and keep. Replace what is in [brackets]. Store your favourites inside a project so they are always where you work.

Library of ready prompts

01 Daily briefing

Review my calendar for today and my unread mail. Give me: 1) meetings with one line of context each, 2) messages needing a reply today, ranked by consequence, 3) one thing I am likely to overlook. Concise bullets, no preamble.

02 Week close

Based on this week's mail and calendar, summarise: what got finished, what is still open, what belongs in next week's plan. Three short lists.

03 Prioritisation by consequence

My list for today: [list]. I have [X] hours. Rank by the size of the consequence if it is NOT done — not by urgency. Then tell me what to delegate, cut or move, one sentence each.

04 Meeting preparation

In [X] hours I meet [whom] about [topic]. Context: [2–3 sentences]. Give me three objectives, five questions to ask, and two hard questions likely to come at me with suggested answers.

05 Notes into actions

Messy notes from a meeting: [paste or photograph]. Turn into: decisions made, actions as who–what–when, and parked items. Mark anything ambiguous with ? rather than guessing.

06 Contract review

Read this contract as a lawyer acting for MY side. List: deadlines and amounts, penalties and exit conditions, unusual or unfavourable clauses, and the questions I should ask before signing.

07 Document summary, three levels

Summarise this on three levels: one sentence on what it is; five key points; what it means specifically for me as [role]. Finish with one important detail that is easy to miss.

08 Data into decisions

Here is a spreadsheet: [describe]. What trends are there, what stands out, and what three decisions does the data actually support? Reason step by step and quote the numbers you are using.

09 Offer comparison

Compare these [X] offers. Table: criteria as rows, offers as columns, including total price, hidden costs and exit terms. Below it: your recommendation and what I should ask each supplier.

10 Batch of files

Here are [X] [invoices/receipts/CVs] for [period]. Build a spreadsheet with columns [list]. Second sheet: summary by [category]. Use only what is in the files — mark anything unreadable "to check". Ask questions before you start.

11 Written in my voice

Here are three pieces of my own writing that capture my voice: [paste]. First, list in three points what characterises it. Then write a [platform] post about [topic] in that voice.

12 Three versions plus a table

Write [email/post/offer] about [topic] for [audience]. Three versions taking genuinely different approaches. Below: a table of version / who it lands with best / main risk. Do not pick a winner.

Library, continued

13 The difficult message

Situation: [describe]. What I want to achieve: [..]. What I want to avoid: [..]. Give me two strategies — for example firm and conciliatory — with a full draft for each, and name the risk of each.

14 Ruthless edit

My text: [paste]. Do not praise it. Tell me: where a reader stops reading, which sentences should be half their length, and where I lose credibility. Then give a revised version plus a list of what you changed.

15 Devil's advocate

Decision: [describe]. My reasons for: [..]. Against: [..]. Argue the other side. Strongest case against, what I am not seeing, and three questions I should answer before deciding. Do not soften it.

16 Let Claude write the prompt

I want to achieve: [rough goal]. Write the ideal prompt I should be giving you — context, constraints, format — and show it to me for approval before you execute it.

17 Automation map

My typical working week: [honest description]. Propose: 1) what I could delegate today, 2) what becomes possible after connectors, 3) what would need building, 4) the top three to start with, each with estimated hours reclaimed per week.

18 The auditor pass

Audit the work above as an auditor being paid to find errors. Check number consistency, internal coherence, gaps and shortcuts. List everything you find, then correct it.

19 Competitor research

Research these companies: [list]. For each: offer and pricing, audience, how they communicate, where they are stronger and weaker than me. About me: [2–3 sentences]. Finish with three things I could implement within thirty days. Use search and give sources.

20 One source, five formats

Source material: [paste]. Turn it into: a LinkedIn post, three short posts, a newsletter email, a sixty-second video script, and five image ideas with captions. Keep my actual arguments — add nothing new.

21 Returning to work

I am returning to professional work after [X] years. During that time I [describe honestly]. Interview me for twenty minutes, one question at a time, about what I actually did — then translate it into the professional language of [sector], framed as evidence rather than apology.

22 Pricing pressure test

You are a sceptical buyer of [service] at [type of organisation]. I am proposing [scope] at [rate]. Push back hard on price, scope and my credibility. Then step out of the role and tell me which of your objections were fair, and how I should have answered.

23 Judgement builder

Explain [concept in my field] properly, at the level of someone with three years' experience. Then I will explain it back to you and you tell me precisely what I got wrong or oversimplified.

24 The uncomfortable mirror

Here is my calendar for the last month: [paste or connect]. Based only on where my time actually went, tell me what a competent outsider would say I am optimising for — and whether that matches what I say my priorities are.

ABOUT

Ada Margo Marglewska

INNOVATION ARCHITECT · ESG STRATEGIST · DOCTORAL RESEARCHER

I design systems — business models, ventures, and the frameworks that hold them together. I work as an innovation architect and interim executive, and I split my life between Poland and Norway, which turns out to be a useful vantage point for noticing which business assumptions are universal and which are merely local.

I am a doctoral candidate at the University of Oslo researching business resilience, a contributor to MIT Sloan Management Review, and an inventor — my work on quantum composites for building-integrated photovoltaics sits at the intersection of deep technology and the energy transition. Alongside that I develop proprietary frameworks for innovation and business-model design, and I use the UN's seventeen Sustainable Development Goals as my strategic compass rather than as decoration.

I am an ambassador for women in business. That is not a title I was given; it is a description of where I put my time. Most of it goes to women over forty who are building something new with two decades of expertise behind them and no patience left for being talked down to. Increasingly it also goes to the generation entering work now, and to the parents of the generation after that.

This book exists because I kept giving the same advice in the same conversations, and it deserved to be written down properly.

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IF THIS WAS USEFUL

Tell me which chapter changed something, and which one fell flat. I rewrite this guide roughly twice a year, and reader corrections are the reason each edition is better than the last. Write to me — I answer everyone.

In pictures

A working life, in eleven frames. Captions to be written in by hand — or left blank, which is also an answer.

 photo 01

01

 photo 02

02

 photo 03

03

 photo 04

04

 photo 05

 photo 06

05

06

In pictures, continued

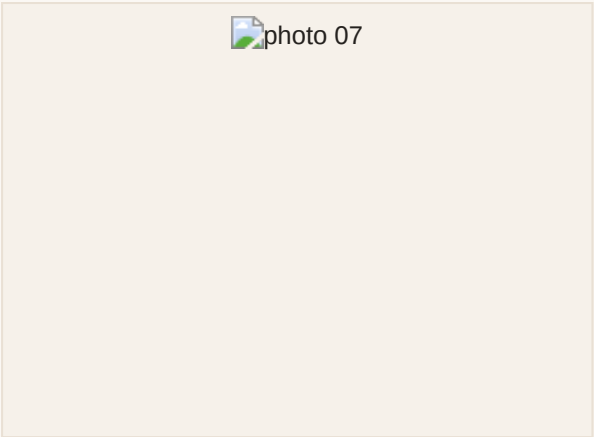


photo 07

07

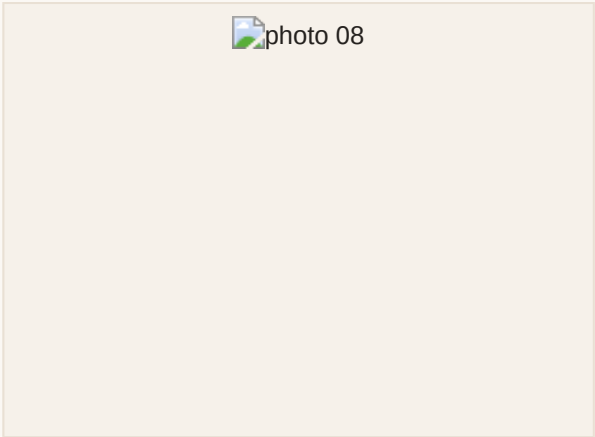


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08

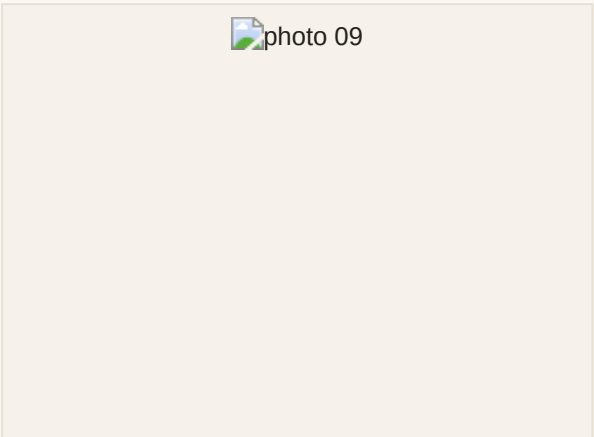


photo 09

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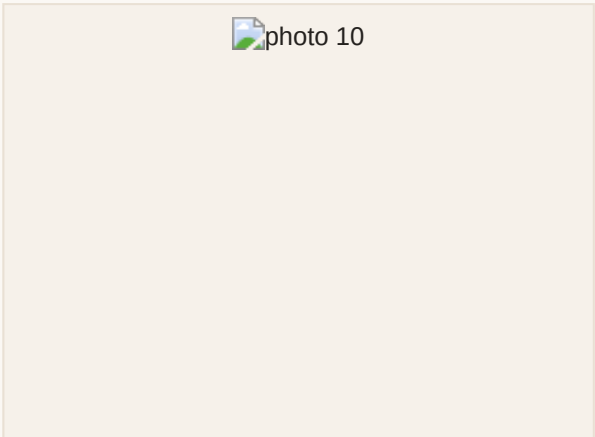


photo 10

10

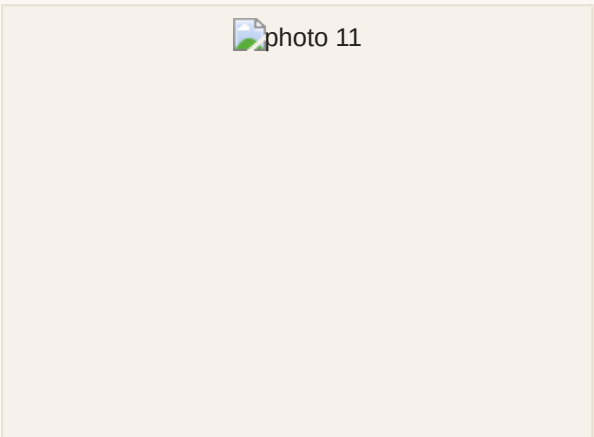


photo 11

CONTACT

Let's talk

If one chapter of this book changed how a week of yours runs, I would like to hear which one. If a chapter fell flat, I would like to hear that even more.

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You do not need to become a different person to use
this well.

You only need to give yourself permission to reclaim a
few hours a week — and then decide what you will do
with them.

Claude, Practically — At Your Pace
Your next chapter starts here.

An invitation — the Kongevegen Circle

This last page has nothing to do with software. Consider it the postscript I would add if I were handing you this book in person.

A book about reclaiming hours ought to say something about what the hours are for. Mine increasingly go towards a question that no productivity method answers: how do people who are genuinely building something find each other?

So I am assembling a small, deliberately selected circle of people working on something meaningful, who would like to meet others of similar calibre. Clear criteria instead of an algorithm. We meet outdoors, because conversations go further on a trail than across a conference table.

How it works

- **First gathering:** Tricity, Poland — October 2026, first twenty people.
- **Then:** the May long weekend, 2027, in Poland.
- **And:** New Year's Eve 2027, in the Norwegian mountains.

Two steps to join

1. Follow me on LinkedIn: [linkedin.com/in/ada-margo-marglewska-31699a251](https://www.linkedin.com/in/ada-margo-marglewska-31699a251)
2. Write to ada@ada-margo.com with one question — the question you consider genuinely important to ask a life partner. The question tells me more about a person than any answer would.

The criteria are open

- Real work on your own project, company or research.
- A contribution to shared knowledge — we are all the experiment here.
- A culture of conversation, and of genuine curiosity about other people.

I reply to everyone. Invitations go to those whose application I can verify. What you write to me stays between us, and serves one purpose only: building the group.

Why the mountains

Kongevegen is an award-winning road completed in 1793 — the first route passable by horse and carriage between eastern and western Norway, connecting Christiania with Bergen. Today it is a hundred-kilometre trail running from Valdres over the Filefjell mountains down to Lærdal on the Sognefjord, and it received a Europa Nostra award in 2017. Along the route stands Maristova, a wayside

inn founded around 1390 by order of Queen Margaret, whose keepers held a royal obligation to receive travellers and give them shelter.

A road that connects two sides of a country, and a house whose whole purpose is hospitality. I have not found a better description of what we are building here.

This is about quality, and about selection.

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Thank you for the hour.

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